

Rage

Soft, alone. Driving, night. He knew the droughts had held him by the arm and asked him, earnestly, to face up. To accept it. His profession fell away, his experiences with patients did too. He wrenched at the hand. It wouldn't give and he felt as powerless as a child in a parent's grip. Something, however odd it might have been, began to click for him: while yes the grip was cold and hard, it was still only so in relative terms. If the moon could hold him accountable, perhaps the sun might free him. If the moon's clasp too resolute, maybe the sun could persuade a softer course. But yes, driving. Alone, soft. And always at night. Dr. Otsuka craved drives after droughts. It was his only way to avoid the fear of their blanknesses. This drive, though, was different. It was a drive of remembering. Of how he'd been, of *what* he'd been in this last. If he weren't so explicitly craving the drive, he'd probably encourage someone in his shoes to do something similar themselves anyway. So why not. Burn some gas, animate an engine.

Impossible to know, but images sometimes came to the surface of his mind lately. Impossible to know. Impossible. Yet he still wondered if these images came from the moon too, like the droughts. Could you even say that droughts were "coming from" the moon, did that even make—

The images. His glasses wrapped around his thigh, almost about to slip to the floor, and his hand wiping away at his face. It reminded him of the times he'd have to use his wipers once or twice, in manual mode, and no more than that. On those days of scant rain. The subset days of the subset days. Except here he was, facing himself in a way he hadn't ever allowed for himself. And only a few tears. He didn't even need his sleeve for this few. Felt wrong. All that work and only this? Only a handful? Starving farmers must feel the same: a season of work for beet blood droplets.

He'd woken up in his bed. Caroline had been there, waiting for him. Driving now and looking back at this, he wanted to scoff. As if he himself were the patient. Although she had something for him and he recognized now that it was something he'd needed. And she? Uniquely positioned to afford it to him. The scoff, suppressed it again. Good at that apparently.

More droplets. This time for the windshield. Caroline showing him had been odd enough on its own. He didn't even immediately recognize her—yet there she was, sleeping in his chair by the bed. Jolted up when she realized he was starting to wake. It took some time, but she eventually showed him a stethoscope. One that he recognized in his heart but found nowhere in his mind, and she began to explain that he needed to take his shirt off so she could "read" him. To him. *To me?* he'd said. *Yes,* she'd responded, without any elaboration. With his shirt where his dog used to lay, she began to read his heart.

Maybe that's why the tears weren't coming here in the car: they'd already poured in the bed. He had had trouble breathing at times during her reading.

His shirt soaked by the end, from his reaching for something to dry himself. He didn't know much about Christianity but part of him imagined that the reading wasn't unlike the Latin readings of old. And she? Impossible as ever. Her words came to him like *pharmakon*, marching molecule-by-molecule into his ears. And she? Ears plugged by the stethoscope. She'd brought it out from an old doppel bag after explaining a little of what they were about to do. Its leather brand new, despite her explanation of where it came from. When she first pulled out the stethoscope, made contact with it I mean,—impossible. I'll try, but her reaction. Just, impossible. "Measure twice, cut once"—sure, if you like. But by contrast, this kind of measuring didn't matter. Wasn't countable, came in lump-sum and as a loaf. Because he later learned, later knew precisely what she began to feel and to see. Of him.

She was holding his childhood. And her reaction to its touch. Her reaction tasted just as good as her reading. Her tone, her mood. Laughter and tears,—and sap that would go on to become amber to the historians of their time. For now it was to be felt and heard and seen and...—by she and him. No one else.

In unfamiliar, foreign words, she narrated the moments he felt safest in his childhood. And those moments he'd never shared with anyone? Well she narrated those too. He discovered a love for himself she herself was discovering for him, too. For they each realized that, on this reading, that the truth and the reality of what he carried needed another to be truly real. Without her, without her seeing him in all his vulnerability, without *that*, his carried-self could be no more than a mirage: to him or to anyone else. And the love. Yes, the love. It stretched his heart like the sails of a boat that had been docked for years; or swelled the very same heart of his but as if it were a kite, with streamer and string and sinew. Air escaped through the gaps and tears of his heart's sails, his heart's fabric—but the lost air paled in comparison to the snapping and the popping and the cracking of his heart's skeleton, for the first time in... He recalled that horses liked to be rode, as Caroline thanked him and left. Her story became a black box to him as she walked out of his awareness, with embers freshly scraped off his soul. A whisper of awe in her shutting of the door.

Driving, alone. Soft and fast. Much like his childhood. She knew him now. And she knew that he hadn't ever really quite known himself up to then either. He felt less alone. A town, a population of 2 in his heart, it seemed. Caroline had a way with hearts, and it occurred to him that no one ever did anything without being in accordance with their own heart. The most saintly, the most vile: all did what felt right to them, even under duress, they did what felt right under that duress.

Driving through the night soft, alone, and fast: Dr. Otsuka said it, spoke through entombed and adorned and encrusted teeth. I was a woman in this last drought. I thought that part was gone, left when I was teenager. It's not. It didn't.

Few pharoahs wake from death. Fewer still wake on the other side with all their garments. This one did both. To be a body willing world's next moon-loss and to be a heart yearning his own gain of sated ache. Otsuka listened to his heart with his palm. No sawteeth or flutter waves, but a wave of acknowledgement nestled nonetheless somewhere in his heart's work, he knew. Why she had left, he didn't know, but regardless he wondered at the state of his heart's census: did his heart count, did her departure reduce it, is it empty when he is forgetful?